

SABER-TOOTHED HUNTER

SMILODON

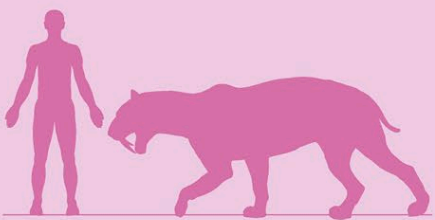
One of the top predators of its time, *Smilodon* is an ancient relative of today's cats. This giant feline preyed on deer and tapirs in forests across the region that is now the Americas and is famous for the daggerlike canine teeth that it used to attack its prey. Many *Smilodon* fossils show wounds in the bones of the shoulders and back—a likely result of the creature ambushing its prey while hunting. Some skull fossils show puncture marks made by saberlike canines, suggesting that these prehistoric cats may have even fought one another, with fatal consequences.

Ambush predator

Stalking through the undergrowth, *Smilodon* probably ambushed its victims by pouncing on them. It would then use its powerful arms to stop the struggling prey from moving too much before delivering its fatal bites.

AT A GLANCE

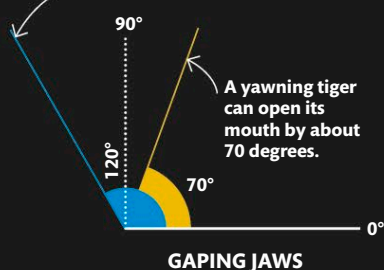
- **LENGTH** 8 ft (2.5 m)
- **DIET** Carnivore
- **LIVED** 2.5–1 MYA
- **HABITAT** Forests and grasslands



STATS AND FACTS

The smallest member of this genus, *Smilodon gracilis*, weighed around 165 lb (75 kg), while the largest, *Smilodon populator*, might have tipped the scales at 1,036 lb (470 kg).

In order to clear the huge canines, *Smilodon* could open its mouth by a whopping 120 degrees.



POWERFUL SKULL

Smilodon had a thick skull, which helped it deal with the impact of delivering a stabbing bite. It housed a pair of 11-in (28-cm) long canines that extended well below the lower jaws. These grew around $\frac{1}{8}$ in (6 mm) per month and stopped growing when *Smilodon* was a little over 3 years old.

Although *Smilodon* is usually shown with a patterned coat, paleontologists are uncertain whether this animal's coat was plain or patterned.

